

MOVIE

Spider-Man: No Way Home

★★★★★ | "With great power, comes great responsibility," has been a central tenet of all spidey films. However, that there are also consequences to such powers, is something which was perhaps missing from the MCU trilogy's previous movies, Spiderman: Homecoming and Far From Home, with Peter Parker having been guided by mentor and guardian angel Tony Stark for the duration of the former, and having his identity being protected at least until the end of the latter.

This, however, changes with No Way Home, with plenty of ghosts from Spiderman's past making an appearance, forcing Peter Parker to battle stakes higher than ever before. Being the web-slinging vigilante that is the Friendly Neighbourhood Spiderman has an



impact on Peter's relationship with aunt May, his friends Ned Leeds and Michelle Jones or MJ. In addition to this, the movie also depicts how living a life ridden with controversy, being either loved or hated with no in between, has an impact on the everyday life of a high school student applying to their dream colleges.

In addition to this, Doctor Strange also plays an integral, although thankfully, not

central part in the film. In many ways, one may think of Peter's relationship with him as similar to that of Stark's, sometimes strained, but mostly one of mutual love, respect, and admiration. Strange's powers of mirror dimensions, as well as many alternate realities being present, give Jon Watts' No Way Home an almost Christopher Nolan-esque feel. Furthermore, the film also has plenty of easter eggs from the past, perhaps the most pivotal one being the location of the final battle being the Statue of Liberty, which, with its torch now being replaced by the iconic star spangled shield.

The multitude of characters and references to the past mean one may have to be extremely well versed with past Spider-Man movies, as well as the MCU in general to be able to make sense of it. However, at the same time, provided one is, Spider-Man: No Way Home is an absolute must watch for Spidey fans, and perhaps may well be the biggest film in the franchise, and a befitting conclusion to the same.

—Atreya Raghavan

TV SHOW

The Witcher S2

★★★★★ | The first season of The Witcher took everyone by surprise by being one of the few successful live-action video game adaptations. Then again, the series is based on the books, so we guess not really a video game adaptation? Anyway, we're assuming you've already watched the first season before reading this review, if you haven't, slight spoilers ahead.

The second season continues where the first left off, right after Ciri and Geralt finally unite. However, their meeting is not under what one might call happy circumstances, as Yennefer has quite literally just burnt an entire army to crisp somewhere in the vicinity. As one might expect, she ends up paying a very heavy price for this act of magic. She wakes up in chains, captured by the surviving enemies, and the heavy realisation of



what she has lost. However, when an opportunity arises to regain what she has lost, she's willing to pay almost any cost, including her relationship with Geralt. This is a bit of a theme with Yennefer we guess, who's always looking for things she can't have, and ends up losing what she does have.

The season also takes a closer look at the relationship between Ciri and Geralt, which is now akin to that of a daughter and father. While Geralt wants Ciri to stay as far away from

danger as possible, Ciri wants to run to the fight and avenge her family. We see them slowly start to understand each other better, with Geralt struggling to play the father-figure and Ciri stuck in the past. We've got a lot of new characters this season as well, including some familiar faces if you're coming from the games. We'll avoid naming them here for the sake of spoilers, but we were overall pretty happy with the characters and the casting.

The plot is arguably less convoluted than the first season, which some found to be a bit confusing because of the different timelines. The pacing is also a lot slower this time around, but there's a healthy sprinkling of action thrown in, which are brilliantly choreographed, as expected. We haven't read the books so we can't say whether the series is accurate or has messed up, but as fans of the games we certainly enjoyed the series. Even fans of fantasy, in general, should definitely pick The Witcher up, which now has two good seasons under its belt.

—Manish Rajesh